

New Puppy Checklist

Everything to actually have ready before your puppy comes home — and what can wait. You're going to want to buy everything; in a week your puppy will have used about three things from that pile. This is the honest, non-negotiable version.

The non-negotiables

- **Food** — the same brand the breeder or shelter was already feeding. Switch later, gradually, if you want to.
- **A crate that actually fits** your puppy's current size, with room to grow (or a divider).
- **A well-fitted collar or harness**, and a plain 6-foot leash — skip the retractable one for now.
- **Bowls** — steel or ceramic, not plastic. Easier to clean, last longer.
- **A bathroom spot already picked out**, before the first day.
- **An ID tag with a current phone number** — on before the first walk, not after.

Puppy-proofing, the honest version

Get down on the floor in every room before your puppy arrives — not metaphorically. You'll spot things you'd never notice standing up.

- Cords and cables within reach — teething puppies chew almost anything at nose height.
- Houseplants that are toxic to dogs (check the ASPCA's list if you're unsure about yours).
- Cleaning products, medication, and small swallowable things — coins, rubber bands, a stray sock.
- Baby gates for any room you're not ready to fully puppy-proof yet.
- Gaps in your fence — puppies are more determined and more flexible than you expect.

Worth the money vs. skip it for now

- **Worth it:** a few sturdy chew toys built for teething, a proper enzymatic cleaner for accidents (regular cleaner leaves a scent trace that invites a repeat), and a baby gate if you're not proofing the whole house.
- **Skip it for now:** the expensive bed (they'll likely chew it), a large wardrobe of outfits, and any single "do everything" toy — a few varied, simple ones hold attention better.

Full guide, including a room-by-room walkthrough and the potty training schedule:

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